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(AI-Generated Session Notes)

AEO for the Strategic Leader

Date & time: Oct. 15, 10:00-10:35 AM
Track: Strategic AI



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Session Description

LLMs are where your buyers are forming opinions before they ever visit your site. 51% of B2B buyers now say AI chat is their top shortlist source. Yet most marketing teams are still optimizing for a discovery model that's rapidly shifting underneath them.

This session shares what we've learned from Webflow's first-party data across millions of websites, from co-hosting the first AEO Conf with leaders from OpenAI, Reddit, and G2, and from hundreds of CMO conversations about what's actually working. You'll get Webflow's AEO Maturity Model, a four-track framework (Content, Technical, Authority, Measurement), to map where your team is today and what to prioritize next. We'll cover the data that matters, the data that misleads, and the specific plays that are driving measurable pipeline from AI-referred traffic.

You'll walk away with an actionable playbook, the data behind it, and specific actions you can take back to your team immediately.

Key Quote

> *"Good AEO is close to what good SEO always should have been."* **- Guy Yalif**

Session Summary

Guy Yalif, Chief Evangelist at Webflow, drew on 15 years in advertising technology through CMO, a decade co-founding and running an AI website personalization company, and a front-row seat to the early days of search at Yahoo. His session focused on answer engine optimization (AEO) and why it matters now: a G2 survey found 51% of B2B buyers start with an LLM more often than Google, and 69% said they chose a different vendor because of what an LLM told them.

To baseline how brands are doing, Webflow built an AEO maturity model and an assessment it ran on 2,000 U.S. websites. On average, brands appeared in just 16% of the answers they want to be in, were cited only 6% of the time, and showed up in 15% of competitive conversations. Sentiment was neutral, accuracy was mixed, and message pull-through was basically non-existent. Most companies (73%) sat at level two of the five-level scale, yet moving from level one to level three was associated with 2.3x more mentions and 3.7x more citations. Yalif's message: it's early innings, and if you feel behind on AEO, you probably aren't.

Yalif organized the path from good SEO to good AEO into four tracks. In content, the shift is from keywords to answering the questions prospects ask through the funnel, and keeping content fresh, since 54% of sites had more than 90% of their content older than six months. In technical, the gaps were fundamentals such as broken internal links, messy header structure, missing metadata, and absent schema, which only 12% of sites (2% in B2B) had. In authority, widespread plain-text mentions matter more than backlinks, so brand, digital PR, and author bios gain importance. In measurement, leaders should track LLM-referred traffic and conversion alongside visibility, citations, share of voice, and sentiment.

He backed the framework with Webflow's own anecdotal tests: updating content 5x faster drove 42% more LLM visits in two months with a 14% higher conversion rate, table of contents in blog posts lifted LLM traffic 59% in four weeks, and adding FAQs plus schema to six product pages captured 57% of incremental citations in two weeks. Webflow's LLM-referred traffic converts six times better than unbranded organic search, and the company now appears in 67% of the answers it cares about.

Yalif closed by urging leaders to ignore the churn of model changes, fix the fundamentals, and build a rapid learning loop of measuring, experimenting, and iterating. He also previewed a work-in-progress AI-native maturity framework for how marketing teams operate, and in Q&A predicted that once fundamentals are fixed, the advantage will come from customer intimacy and speed of learning, while advising teams to deprioritize LLMs.txt.

Key Takeaways

- **Fix the fundamentals first:** Broken internal links, poor header structure, and missing metadata are holding most sites back, and if your site has a bunch of broken links, nothing else matters.
- **Answer questions, not keywords:** Build content around the questions prospects ask throughout the funnel, using sales call recordings, sales emails, and support emails as ground truth.
- **Keep content fresh and accurate:** LLMs favor recently updated content and look for consensus, so outdated or inaccurate pages and profiles can actively harm how your brand is represented.
- **Earn mentions, not just links:** Authority in AEO comes from widespread plain-text mentions, which makes brand, digital PR, and executive thought leadership more important than ever.
- **Use schema to get ahead:** Only 12% of sites (2% in B2B) have schema, and Webflow saw six product pages with FAQs and schema capture 57% of its incremental citations in two weeks.
- **Measure and learn rapidly:** Track LLM-referred traffic and conversion with your existing tools, then run a fast loop of measuring, experimenting, implementing, and reviewing results.